

STUDY COMPANION

The Out-of-Sync Child

Third Edition

Recognizing and Coping with Sensory Processing Differences

Carol Stock Kranowitz

Read for the audiobook by Ellen Archer

OUTLINE · ACTION GUIDE · QUICK REFERENCE

THE FRAMEWORK

Three Movements

How this companion is organized

Carol Kranowitz's book divides naturally into two parts — recognizing sensory differences, then coping with them. This companion follows that arc but splits the long first part where it genuinely seams, at the sense-by-sense chapters, giving three movements. Fourteen chapters, one steady message: your out-of-sync child is not broken, and help is at hand.

I • Recognize Chapters 01–04

Seeing the Out-of-Sync Child. Before you can help a child, you have to see clearly what you are looking at. This first movement introduces four out-of-sync children, defines sensory processing differences in plain language, separates them from the conditions they resemble, and lays out how sensory processing actually works — and what happens when it doesn't.

II • Decode the Senses Chapters 05–09

The Sense-by-Sense Tour. Beneath the familiar five senses sit the hidden ones that give a child a sense of herself in the world. This movement takes each sense in turn — touch, balance, body position, sight, and sound — showing how it is meant to work and the recognizable patterns that appear when it is out of sync.

III • Support & Thrive Chapters 10–14

Coping and Building a Sensory-Smart Life. Recognition is only the beginning. This final movement turns understanding into action: how to get a diagnosis and the right therapy, how to build a sensory-enriched life at home, how to make school work, how to cope with the emotional fallout, and how to see your child — at last — in a new light.

Movement I

Recognize

Seeing the Out-of-Sync Child

Before you can help a child, you have to see clearly what you are looking at. This first movement introduces four out-of-sync children, defines sensory processing differences in plain language, separates them from the conditions they resemble, and lays out how sensory processing actually works — and what happens when it doesn't.

01 Four Out-of-Sync Children

02 Does Your Child Have Sensory Processing Differences?

03 Does Your Child Have Another Diagnosis?

04 Understanding Sensory Processing

01 • Four Out-of-Sync Children

at Home and School

“The child who is out of sync needs understanding and support, for no child can overcome the obstacles alone.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Tommy, a fussy three-year-old, greets the world with “oh no” — shoes too tight, socks too lumpy, hats and mittens refused even in the cold, cuddling rejected, the playground and bathtub avoided — yet he is the world's best block builder as long as no one crowds him.
- Vicki, a pudgy first-grader in a daze, answers the world with “wait, what?” She bumps into furniture, tires easily (“I'm too pooped”), and dreams of being a ballerina, but only comes alive after pushing a doll carriage loaded with books or swinging for a long time.
- Paul, a shy ten-year-old, meets challenges with “I can't do that — what's the point?” An above-average reader, he is paralyzed writing a paper: a death grip on the pencil, elbow pinned to his ribs, tongue out, often sliding off his chair.
- Sebastian, eight, cries “more, more, more.” He fidgets constantly, riffles pages, taps rulers, snaps pencils, chews his collar — the boy who has “gotta touch and gotta move,” who knocks over the glue the instant the teacher says don't.

CORE LESSON

Four healthy, bright, dearly loved children look nothing alike, yet share one problem — sensory processing disorder — in how they manage ordinary sensations, plan their actions, and regulate their attention.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 SPD wears different faces. The over-responsive avoider, the under-responsive straggler, the motor-planning child, and the sensory craver look like four different problems but share one root.
- 2 These children are healthy, intelligent, and loved. The struggle is in processing sensation — not in intelligence, effort, or attachment.
- 3 Well-meaning labels miss the point. “He's spoiled,” “she's lazy,” “he'll grow out of it” mistake a neurological difference for a character flaw.
- 4 No child can overcome these obstacles alone. Every out-of-sync child needs understanding and support to find his way.

02 • Does Your Child Have Sensory Processing Differences?

Common Symptoms and the Continuum

“The inability to get through the day smoothly is not because the child won't, but because he can't.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Pioneer occupational therapist Dr. A. Jean Ayres was the first to describe sensory difficulties as differences in the central nervous system, developing the theory of sensory integration in the mid-twentieth century.
- A child yanks the cat's tail; the cat hisses and spits. A typical child learns caution. The child with SPD may miss the cat's cues, or read them yet be unable to stop himself — receiving the information but unable to organize a response.
- Six informal “types” give plain words for what parents see: the Avoider (“oh no”), the Straggler (“wait, what?”), the Craver (“more!”), the Jumbler (“what does that mean?”), the Slumper (“don't want to”), and the Fumbler (“I can't do that”).
- Johnny, once so severe that he carried a stick as a buffer and shouted “you're fired,” got occupational therapy twice a week and a sensory-enriched life. By ten he played soccer and read a book a week; today he's a journalist in Europe. His teacher said, “I wish I had 24 other Johnnies.”

CORE LESSON

SPD is a problem in the central nervous system's handling of sensation — receiving, connecting, interpreting, and using it — that lives on a continuum from mild difference to full disorder.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 It's a matter of can't, not won't. SPD is a difference in how the nervous system processes sensation, not a question of willpower, intelligence, or discipline.
- 2 It comes in three families: modulation (over-responsive, under-responsive, craving), discrimination, and sensory-based motor — postural challenges and dyspraxia.
- 3 It lives on a continuum, judged by frequency, intensity, and duration, and it rarely travels alone — touching eating, sleep, toileting, attention, and emotions.
- 4 The young brain is plastic. Untreated, children don't grow out of SPD — they grow into it — but with therapy and a sensory-enriched life, dramatic change is possible. Hope is at hand.

03 • Does Your Child Have Another Diagnosis?

Lookalikes and Overlappers

“The red flags are a child's unusual responses to touching and being touched, or to moving and being moved.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- The numbers show how often SPD overlaps: about forty percent of children with ADHD also have SPD, and roughly ninety-five percent of autistic children do too.
- The very same behaviors — fidgeting, distractibility, not listening — appear in ADHD, in undiagnosed vision problems, in allergies and nutritional gaps, and in perfectly typical children under seven.
- Twin brothers Cesar and Felipe come home to grandparents Abuela and Abuelo, who offer just-right sensory strategies: a long rocking hug and a therapy ball for Cesar, a gluten-free pretzel and shoulder pressure for Felipe, who finds churro ridges confusing on his tongue.
- Temple Grandin felt touch as torment until she built her own squeeze machine, yet craved visual sensation — striped shirts, sliding supermarket doors — and turned that sensitivity into a doctorate in animal science.

CORE LESSON

SPD does not cause but does complicate other conditions, and because so many sensory symptoms are common to them all, careful diagnosis — not a quick label — is what points to the right treatment.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 SPD rarely travels alone. It overlaps heavily with ADHD, autism, and learning disabilities such as dyslexia, dysgraphia, and dyscalculia.
- 2 Surface behaviors mislead. The same fidgeting and distractibility appear in SPD, ADHD, vision problems, allergies, and typical young children — and the treatments differ.
- 3 A useful distinguisher: a child with ADHD notices a novel sensation and adjusts to it; a child with SPD may never register it or never stop reacting — and, unlike ADHD kids, often calms with the right sensory input.
- 4 Sensitivity can be a gift. The goal is to identify the specific profile so that intervention fits the child, not to pin on a label.

04 · Understanding Sensory Processing

and What Can Go Amiss

“Having SPD does not imply brain damage or disease, but rather what Dr. Ayres called indigestion of the brain — a traffic jam in the brain.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- We have not five senses but eight: the familiar five, plus three hidden ones — interoception (the inner body and emotion), the vestibular sense (balance), and proprioception (body position) — the ones Ayres called the foundation of a child's sense of self.
- Modulation works like a gas dial under a teakettle: excitation turns the flame up, inhibition turns it down. The over-responsive child is the kettle with the gas turned too high; the under-responsive child, the gas turned too low.
- A meltdown is not a tantrum. As Jed Baker explains, it is an escalating reaction to sensory overload — a private, lonely, scary event the child cannot stop — best prevented, never punished.
- Three everyday responses show the input-organize-output cycle: a blaring horn makes you jump back, a sour plum makes you spit, a tilting beach chair makes you grab the armrests — all in a nanosecond.

CORE LESSON

Sensory processing is a ceaseless cycle of input, organization, and output; when it misfires it isn't damage but a traffic jam, producing recognizable patterns rather than a single symptom.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 We have eight senses. Beneath sight, sound, smell, taste, and touch sit three foundational hidden senses — interoception, the vestibular sense, and proprioception.
- 2 Processing is a cycle: the brain receives, integrates, modulates (balancing excitation and inhibition), and discriminates sensation, then sends out a motor or emotional response.
- 3 When it misfires it isn't brain damage — Ayres called it “indigestion of the brain” — and it shows up as the avoider, straggler, craver, fluctuator, jumbler, slumper, and fumbler.
- 4 A meltdown is an uncontrollable response to overload, best prevented; and because the brain builds level by level like a block tower, the right input can rebuild the foundation.

Movement II

Decode the Senses

The Sense-by-Sense Tour

Beneath the familiar five senses sit the hidden ones that give a child a sense of herself in the world. This movement takes each sense in turn — touch, balance, body position, sight, and sound — showing how it is meant to work and the recognizable patterns that appear when it is out of sync.

05 The Tactile Sense

06 The Vestibular Sense

07 The Proprioceptive Sense

08 The Visual Sense

09 The Auditory Sense

05 · The Tactile Sense

How Touch Protects and Teaches

“Touch is probably more critical to human function throughout life than is generally recognized.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- At circle time with a basket of squashes, Robert grips two plastic dinosaurs and refuses to touch anything, Patrick licks and rolls on the vegetables shouting “I’m a windshield wiper,” and Lena, barely looking, offers only “I see six.”
- The paradox of over-responsivity: the child rubs off a surprise kiss (light, unexpected touch) yet begs for a bear hug (deep pressure), because firm pressure actually quiets the alarm — but only from people on his “okay list.”
- Giorgio falls off his bike, scrapes both knees, and rides on — “it doesn’t hurt” — while Cody happily kneads pretzel dough until a saxophone squeaks and suddenly he can’t stand the dough on his hands another second.
- Touch is the ground floor for body awareness, motor planning, visual discrimination, language, emotional attachment, and social skill — which is why “touchy” is a funny word for people who avoid touch.

CORE LESSON

Touch has two jobs — a protective side that flags danger and a discriminative side that tells you what you’re feeling — and it is the foundation for far more than comfort.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Touch has two components: a protective side that says “uh-oh” and a discriminative side that says “aha.” Either can be out of tune.
- 2 The great paradox: the over-responsive child flees light, unexpected touch yet craves deep pressure, which actually calms him — and he accepts it only from trusted people.
- 3 Touch is the foundation of body awareness, motor planning, visual discrimination, language, emotional attachment, and social skill.
- 4 Because avoiders skip the messy, hands-on experiences that build these skills, “the less he does, the less he can do” — so safe, appealing tactile play matters enormously.

06 • The Vestibular Sense

Balance, Gravity, and Movement

“The vestibular system is the unifying system. All other types of sensation are processed in reference to this basic vestibular information.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Best friends at the amusement park: Jason, “our little locomotive,” craves the roller coaster and never gets dizzy, while Kevin — nicknamed “NATO,” no action, talk only — is so gravitationally insecure he just wants to raise his arms and shout “go.”
- Housed in the inner ear like a carpenter’s level, the vestibular sense registers every change of head position — Ayres called gravity “the most constant and universal force in our lives.”
- Over-responsivity takes two forms: intolerance to movement (Shawn’s stomach churns during musical chairs) and gravitational insecurity (Brad senses that if his feet leave the ground swinging on the vine, he’ll fall into the void).
- Low muscle tone is a vestibular story: “if you’re a couch potato you probably have low tone — and chances are your child is a potato chip,” because the brain isn’t sending the muscles enough “oomph.”

CORE LESSON

The vestibular sense tells you which way is up and primes every other sense, so when it’s off, balance, tone, coordination, and even reading can wobble.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 The vestibular sense, in the inner ear, is the “unifying system” that tells you which way is up and primes every other sense.
- 2 Over-responsivity comes in two forms: intolerance to movement (dizziness, car sickness) and gravitational insecurity, a primal terror of falling.
- 3 Cravers can’t get enough — spinning without dizziness, climbing everything (“for the sensory craver, everything is a ladder”), darting from thrill to thrill.
- 4 Because it regulates muscle tone, balance, bilateral coordination, and reading eye-movements, vestibular trouble often masquerades as clumsiness, laziness, low self-esteem, or dyslexia.

07 • The Proprioceptive Sense

The Muscle Sense

“Proprioceptive experiences calm and organize us — bringing us up when we are way down, and down when we are way up.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Tony joins the beginner swim team but must watch his every move: he thuds his heels, collides with a chair, faces the wrong way on the ladder, and swims with a “limp” because his two arms won't match — uncoordinated and unaware of his own body.
- Proprioception's quiet superpower is regulating arousal: pushing a wall, pulling tubing, or hanging from a bar can wake a sluggish child or settle an overloaded one — and the calm can last for hours.
- Dinah is stiff and clumsy after an hour with Harry Potter, so her mother gives her heavy-work jobs — scrubbing potatoes, squeezing lemons, tossing the salad — and she comes alert; the smartest move before homework is a burst of resistive play.
- Rasheed rams into other boys on the football field and gets penalized because he can't judge how much force to use — his parents say “he doesn't know his own strength.”

CORE LESSON

Proprioception — the muscle sense in muscles, joints, and tendons — tells you where your body is and how much force it's using, and it is the master regulator of arousal.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Proprioception, the “muscle sense,” tells you where your body parts are and how much force they use — it's why you can tie your shoes in the dark.
- 2 Its superpower is regulating arousal: deep, resistive “heavy work” brings a sluggish child up and a wound-up child down, and the calm lasts for hours.
- 3 So the smartest move before homework or story time is stretching and resistive play — and the craver who crashes into everything is often hunting the input his muscles are starving for.
- 4 When proprioception is weak the child looks like a klutz — spilling, breaking pencils, misjudging force — and rarely alone, since it almost always rides with tactile or vestibular differences.

08 · The Visual Sense

Seeing Versus Sight

“Movement, the basis of all learning, teaches the eyes to make sense of sights.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Two seventh-graders: Francesca, the best reader in the grade, is so over-responsive to visual input she retreats to a library corner facing a blank wall, away from flickering fluorescents; Charity, bright but under-responsive, bumps into a book cart and can't track a line of print.
- Vision is not eyesight. Eyesight is the raw ability to see the big E on the chart; vision is the developed skill of making sense of it — and it is built through movement, touch, and the vestibular and proprioceptive senses.
- The numbers are startling: roughly three-quarters of classroom learning leans on vision, yet about ninety percent of visual problems are never diagnosed and a quarter of school-age students have undiagnosed vision problems.
- Both girls have visual dyspraxia — they can't transpose a kite design onto the kite's wings because relating the parts to the whole is a visual skill they haven't yet built.

CORE LESSON

Vision is the developed skill of making sense of what the eyes see, built through movement — so a child can have perfect eyesight and still have a visual processing problem.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Vision is not eyesight. Eyesight is raw seeing; vision is making sense of what you see, and it's built through movement, touch, and the vestibular and proprioceptive senses.
- 2 A child can have perfect eyesight and still struggle — Francesca reads beautifully yet is overwhelmed by flickering lights; Charity can't find a face in a crowd.
- 3 Because so much classroom learning leans on vision and most visual problems go undiagnosed, sensory-based visual differences masquerade as clumsiness, poor attention, or a reading disability.
- 4 When the trouble travels with movement — tripping, slumping, losing left from right — the root is usually sensory, and a developmental optometrist or OT can bring eyes and body back in sync.

09 • The Auditory Sense

Hearing Versus Listening

“We listen, move, speak, and read with our ear.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- May dreads music Mondays until a new teacher throws out the “sit still” rule: the children bend and stretch to match rising and falling notes, walk and sing slowly, run and sing fast. Suddenly May isn't merely hearing the music — she's incorporating it into her body.
- The auditory system is the first to become functional, developing in the womb and working in tandem with the vestibular system — which is why the two share the same inner-ear hardware.
- Neilia — nicknamed “Nervous Nellie” — never uses the school toilet because the flush is “as deafening as Niagara Falls,” and she jumps out of her skin when a pencil hits the floor; meanwhile Frankie doesn't react at all to a shouted “look out.”
- Because ear and inner ear are linked, movement primes sound: “active movement primes the pump and speech begins to flow,” and putting a child in a swing during speech therapy can have remarkable results.

CORE LESSON

Hearing is the raw reception of sound; listening is a developed skill built alongside the vestibular sense, which is why movement primes speech and language.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Hearing and listening differ: hearing is raw reception, listening a developed skill built with the vestibular sense — “we listen, move, speak, and read with our ear.”
- 2 A child can hear perfectly and still process poorly — May sings off-key because she can't discriminate pitch; Neilia flees a flushing toilet; Frankie doesn't react to a shout.
- 3 Because the auditory and vestibular systems share inner-ear hardware, movement primes sound — swinging, running, and bouncing “prime the pump” so speech and language flow.
- 4 Auditory differences quietly undermine reading, speech, following directions, and social pragmatics, so they're mistaken for not listening — and targeted help can unlock them.

Movement III

Support & Thrive

Coping and Building a Sensory-Smart Life

Recognition is only the beginning. This final movement turns understanding into action: how to get a diagnosis and the right therapy, how to build a sensory-enriched life at home, how to make school work, how to cope with the emotional fallout, and how to see your child — at last — in a new light.

10 Diagnosis and Treatment

11 Your Child at Home

12 Your Child at School

13 Coping with Your Child's Emotions

14 Looking at Your Child in a New Light

10 · Diagnosis and Treatment

Finding the Right Help

“The therapy itself may not last forever, but the results will last a lifetime.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- One exhausted mother searched for answers through a neurologist, a psychologist, an allergist, and an ENT before a neighbor's referral to an occupational therapist finally named it: SPD, at three and a half. “Instead of feeling all alone and desperate, now I'm excited and hopeful.”
- Eight rationalizations delay help — “it's just ADHD,” “not my kid,” “she's advanced for her age,” “he could if he wanted to,” “I was like that and turned out fine” — but no child chooses to be disorganized.
- Parents become detectives, charting both the hard times and the good times: Tommy calms with firm downward back rubs and a “people sandwich” game, Vicki organizes herself by standing on her head and swinging, Paul cracks his knuckles to wake his writing hand and loves hauling water buckets.
- The gold standard is OTSI — occupational therapy using a sensory-integration framework — which doesn't drill the missing skill but follows the child's own inner drive through “just-right” challenges that feel like play.

CORE LESSON

Growing older won't fix a shaky sensory foundation, so the answer is early intervention — documented instincts, a professional evaluation, and occupational therapy that follows the child's own inner drive.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Growing older doesn't fix SPD when the foundation is shaky — the answer is early intervention, and the gold standard is OTSI: occupational therapy using a sensory-integration framework.
- 2 Trust your instincts and document — chart both the hard times and the good times, because anecdotal evidence is as valuable as any test; when you hear hoofbeats, look for horses, not zebras.
- 3 Beware the eight rationalizations. No child chooses to be disorganized, and low self-esteem is itself a red flag worth acting on.
- 4 Good therapy doesn't drill the missing skill; it follows the child's inner drive through “just-right” challenges that feel like play — the therapy ends, but the results last a lifetime.

11 · Your Child at Home

A Sensory-Enriched Life

“A sensory-enriched life is like a fitness plan — it will enhance every child's functioning, whether the child is in or out of sync.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Tonya's parents resisted advice to get her outside — until her energetic little sister demanded daily trips to the playground, and the fearful, limp three-year-old blossomed. “A sensory-enriched life,” her mother realized, “makes a huge difference.”
- A sensory-enriched life is not a rigid clinical “sensory diet.” It weaves three kinds of activity into the day: alerting (crunchy foods, bouncing), organizing (chewing, heavy work, hanging upside down), and calming (deep pressure, slow rocking, back rubs).
- Handed a cardboard tube, most children instantly show its “affordances” — you can look through it, blow through it, roll it — but children with dyspraxia demonstrate far fewer, because “the less they do, the less they can do.”
- Everyday “beautiful junk” becomes therapy: a tactile road of textures, a “people sandwich” pressed between gym mats, a teeter-totter, a T-stool, a laundry basket to haul, a rubber-band harp.

CORE LESSON

Home life gets easier when you weave fun sensorimotor activities into the natural flow of the day — matched to the child's need, led by the child, using ordinary objects full of affordances.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Build a “sensory-enriched life” — fun sensorimotor activities woven into the day — rather than a rigid clinical “sensory diet”; think of it as a fitness plan any child benefits from.
- 2 Match the input to the need: alerting (crunchy foods, bouncing) wakes the under-responder, calming (deep pressure, slow rocking, back rubs) settles the over-responder, and organizing “heavy work” does both.
- 3 Follow the child's lead — supply the input he's already hunting for, let him direct the play, and honor “stop means stop,” because the less he does, the less he can do.
- 4 Everyday objects are therapy in disguise: a cardboard tube, a paper plate, a laundry basket, a teeter-totter — “beautiful junk” full of affordances that builds self-help skills.

12 • Your Child at School

Becoming an Advocate

“The child's primary need is to feel safe. When he feels safe, his brain is available for learning.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Nicky hated fourth grade with a teacher who said “I wish you would just try harder,” but loves fifth grade with a teacher who breaks work into chunks, gives him a chair that doesn't wiggle and pencils that don't break, and never takes away recess.
- Alan was a “sad, scared, helpless loner” behind a barricade of trucks at preschool — yet a lively chatterbox at home. “If only school were more like home,” his mother sighed, and a home-school partnership made it so.
- When one mother asked whether her son could chew gum to focus, the teacher refused — “he cannot have special privileges just because he has special needs” — so she went to the principal; the teacher relented, the boy improved, and months later she apologized.
- The strategies that help this child help every child: reduce overload (“simplify, simplify, simplify”), plan transitions and movement breaks, teach through every sense — “I hear and I forget; I see and I remember; I do and I understand.”

CORE LESSON

School is hard for out-of-sync children for concrete reasons, so the goal is to make it feel more like home — with an informed, advocating parent and strategies that help every child.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 What a difference a teacher — and an informed parent — makes: the child who buckles under a scolding teacher can flourish with one who breaks work into chunks and never takes away recess.
- 2 School is hard for concrete reasons — pressure to conform, abrupt transitions, too much or too little sensory input, and the fact that school isn't the safe, predictable place home is.
- 3 Be your child's advocate: share his needs briefly and positively (skip the jargon, give what-works-at-home tips), pick your battles, and if the fit is wrong, you have options.
- 4 The strategies that help this child help every child — reduce overload, plan transitions and movement, teach through all the senses, keep your voice low, and value process over product.

13 • Coping with Your Child's Emotions

Discipline, Empathy, and Do's and Don'ts

“Just as another child with measles cannot help itching, the child with SPD cannot help being clumsy or afraid.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- Marge's “typically dreadful morning”: Chip falls out of bed, crashes into his little sister, turns his T-shirt inside out so the tags won't hurt (“pretty good problem solving,” thinks Mom, before Dad forces it right side out), pours orange juice on his cereal, then on his sister's head, and misses the bus.
- Discipline means to teach, not to punish. Comment on the behavior, not the child (“yelling makes me angry,” not “you infuriate me”), and prefer natural consequences to imposed ones.
- Respond to the primary emotion, not the defensive behavior — the aggressive child is often the frightened child — and empathize out loud: “I think roller coasters are scary too.”
- The do's come down to a few habits: build on strengths and interests, allow safe self-therapy, give a sense of control, say “I love you” often, keep your cool — and take care of yourself, because no one can pour from an empty cup.

CORE LESSON

The emotional fallout is real and physical, so the first move is always to see the difficulty rather than the defiance — to discipline by teaching and to respond to the fear beneath the behavior.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 The fallout is physical: a child with SPD “cannot help being clumsy or afraid” any more than a child with measles can help itching — so see the difficulty, not the defiance.
- 2 Discipline means to teach, not to punish: comment on the behavior rather than the child, use natural consequences, and offer a calm space rather than shame.
- 3 Respond to the primary emotion, not the defensive behavior — the aggressive child is often the afraid child — and empathize out loud, sharing your own feelings so he learns he isn't alone.
- 4 Build on strengths and interests, allow safe self-therapy, give a sense of control, say “I love you” often — and take care of yourself, because no one can pour from an empty cup.

14 · Looking at Your Child in a New Light

Becoming Enlightened

“The child who is inwardly on the defensive will often be outwardly offensive.”

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

- A skeptical father dismissed “sensory processing” as his wife's overprotectiveness — until a workshop's experience stations, walking a straight line while peering through the wrong end of binoculars, “penetrated my thick skull,” and he began to see his daughter in a new light.
- Enlightenment is a shift in the story you tell: unable, not unwilling; brave, not fearful; needy, not greedy (“she seems greedy because she is needy”); a survivor, not stubborn.
- The same sensitivities that make life hard can be gifts — empathy, creativity, humor, keen observation — so the practice is to think abilities, not disabilities.
- One mother's journey ends where every parent hopes: after two years of therapy and a nurturing school, “we learned to do something I never thought would be possible — we learned to enjoy him. He is our favorite companion.”

CORE LESSON

Enlightenment is a shift in the story you tell about your child — unable not unwilling, brave not fearful, needy not greedy — backed by the everyday love and empathy that is the treatment that never ends.

WHAT KRANOWITZ WANTS YOU TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Enlightenment is a shift in story: unable, not unwilling; brave, not fearful; needy, not greedy; a survivor, not stubborn — “the child who is inwardly on the defensive will often be outwardly offensive.”
- 2 The same sensitivities that make life hard can be gifts — empathy, creativity, humor, keen observation — so think abilities, not disabilities.
- 3 Reframing doesn't excuse the child from life; it equips you to make his life pleasant and safe, because SPD is “indigestion of the brain” that OT and a sensory-enriched life can soothe.
- 4 Your everyday love and empathy are the treatment that never ends — the goal isn't just to manage a child but to reach the day you “learn to enjoy him.”

Part Two

The Action Guide

Observe · Adapt · Advocate

The wisdom of all fourteen chapters, reorganized into the three things a parent actually does: learn to see the child's sensory profile, adapt the home and day around it, and advocate for the child's emotions, schooling, and dignity.

Observe

Learn to See the Profile

Before you can help, you have to understand what you are actually seeing. The work of this phase is detective work: gathering evidence, naming the patterns, and getting a professional read.

1.1 Chart the hard times — and the good times.

Keep dated notes of what triggers a meltdown and what soothes it. Kranowitz insists anecdotal evidence is as valuable as any test, and the patterns that emerge — socks and turtlenecks, finger paint, a specific back rub — are the clues that solve the mystery.

1.2 Ask, “What does he avoid?”

Avoidance often hides inability, not preference. A child who skips the sandbox may not know how to play there rather than dislike it. Look for the ordinary childhood experiences that quietly go missing.

1.3 Learn the eight senses and the six types.

Name what you're seeing — the avoider, straggler, craver, jumbler, slumper, or fumbler — and remember the three hidden foundational senses: vestibular, proprioceptive, and interoceptive. Plain language lets you describe it to a professional.

1.4 Watch for the red flags.

Unusual responses to touch and movement, trouble focusing even on things he loves, few friends, and low self-esteem — which is itself a signal worth acting on.

1.5 Separate SPD from the lookalikes.

The same behaviors appear in ADHD, allergies, vision problems, and typical young children. One useful test: a child with ADHD adjusts to a novel sensation, while a child with SPD may never register it or never stop reacting.

1.6 Trust your instincts — then get an evaluation.

An occupational therapist is the professional who evaluates suspected SPD. In the United States, start with early intervention (under three) or your local school district (three and up); the crucial question is “what kind of SPD is this?”

1.7 Keep a chronological record.

A dated notebook of your observations, teachers' notes, and evaluations lets patterns surface and gives you evidence if you ever need to prove your child requires services.

Adapt

Build the Sensory-Smart Life

Understanding becomes help when you change the environment and the day. The goal is a sensory-enriched life — flexible, playful, and matched to your child's nervous system — that gets him in sync.

2.1 Build a sensory-enriched life, not a rigid diet.

Weave fun sensorimotor activities into the natural flow of the day — after breakfast, after school, before bed. Think of it as a fitness plan for the nervous system, enjoyable for the whole family.

2.2 Match the input to the need.

Alerting input — crunchy foods, a shower, bouncing — wakes the under-responder. Calming input — deep pressure, slow rocking, a firm back rub — settles the over-responder.

2.3 Lead with heavy work.

Pushing, pulling, carrying, and hanging both calm and organize, and the effect can last for hours. Schedule a burst of it right before homework, story time, or bed.

2.4 Follow the child's lead — and honor “stop means stop.”

Supply the input he's already hunting for, let him direct the play, and watch his nonverbal cues; relaxation means keep going, raucous laughter means it's time to cool down.

2.5 Turn everyday objects into therapy.

A cardboard tube, paper plate, laundry basket, or teeter-totter is full of “affordances.” Because the less he does the less he can do, low-cost “beautiful junk” gives him dozens of chances to practice.

2.6 Support self-help with small steps.

Comfortable clothes, a tipless cup, a step-stool for grounding, a star chart, and chores broken into one-plate-at-a-time build competence and, with it, confidence.

2.7 Prepare the child for therapy as fun.

Frame it as a gym with great toys, insist on a good fit with the therapist, and remember: the child's own inner drive is the single factor that makes therapy work.

Advocate

Protect Emotions, School, and the Relationship

The final work is emotional and relational: shielding your child's sense of self, opening doors at school, and shifting the story you tell about who he is. This is where love does its quiet, lasting work.

3.1 See the difficulty, not the defiance.

A child with SPD cannot help being clumsy or afraid. Respond to the primary emotion — usually fear — rather than the behavior on the surface, because the aggressive child is often the frightened child.

3.2 Discipline to teach, not to punish.

Comment on the behavior rather than the child, use natural consequences, and offer a calm space instead of shame when he loses control — losing control is frightening enough.

3.3 Make school feel more like home.

Ask teachers to reduce sensory overload, plan transitions and movement breaks, teach through every sense, keep their voices low, and value process over product, participation over perfection.

3.4 Be an articulate advocate.

Tell teachers briefly and positively what works at home — skip the jargon, share the tips — pick your most important battles, and if the fit is wrong, you have options from a new classroom to homeschooling.

3.5 Give a sense of control and safe outlets.

Offer real choices, a place to scream, something safe to punch, and reassurance. Say “I love you” — you cannot say it too often.

3.6 Reframe the story you tell.

Unable not unwilling, brave not fearful, needy not greedy, a survivor not stubborn. Think abilities, not disabilities — and let the child overhear the kinder story.

3.7 Take care of yourself — and don't go it alone.

You cannot pour from an empty cup. Support is out there, SPD is a problem a child cannot overcome alone, and your everyday love is the treatment that never ends.

PRINTABLE

Quick Reference

One principle per chapter — clip it to the fridge

- 01 There is no single “look” to SPD — the avoider, the straggler, the fumbler, and the craver all struggle to organize ordinary sensation.
- 02 It's not that he won't; it's that he can't. SPD is a difference in the nervous system, not in willpower.
- 03 SPD rarely travels alone — the same behaviors appear in ADHD, autism, and typical young children, so pinpoint the profile.
- 04 We have eight senses; three hidden ones — vestibular, proprioceptive, interoceptive — are the foundation everything else is built on.
- 05 Touch has two jobs: it protects (uh-oh) and it teaches (aha). The over-responder flees light touch but craves deep pressure.
- 06 The vestibular sense tells you which way is up and primes every other sense — when it's off, everything wobbles.
- 07 Proprioception, the muscle sense, both calms and arouses: heavy work before homework settles a child for hours.
- 08 Vision is not eyesight — it's built by moving, so a child can see the E on the chart yet not make sense of what he sees.
- 09 Hearing is not listening — because the ear and inner ear share hardware, movement primes speech and sound.
- 10 Growing older won't fix it; early OT using a sensory-integration framework will — and good therapy feels like play.
- 11 Build a sensory-enriched life, not a rigid diet: match alerting, organizing, or calming input to the moment.
- 12 Make school feel more like home — reduce overload, plan transitions and movement, and be your child's advocate.
- 13 Discipline means to teach, not punish; respond to the primary emotion (usually fear), and take care of yourself too.
- 14 Unable, not unwilling; brave, not fearful; needy, not greedy — think abilities, not disabilities.

“With your knowledge about sensory processing, and with your loving support, your child can flourish and grow to become in sync with the world.”

— Carol Stock Kranowitz